
HOMOGENIZATION OR DIVERSIFICATION? THE IMPACT OF GLOBALIZATION ON CULTURAL IDENTITY OF THE FIRST AND SECOND-GENERATION IMMIGRANTS

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Globalization's accelerating influence has been at the forefront of the debate on the potential ramifications of cultures' homogenization. Research has shown that with the increased migration, the world is becoming more multi-culturally diverse, nonetheless more homogenized. This study aims at determining if globalization has positively impacted the participants' cultural identities and lives and examines if this phenomenon leads to the homogenization of cultures. An ethnographic study was conducted on 32 participants from the first and second-generation migrants, originating from 21 countries, to depict globalization's real impact on their cultural identities and lives. The research used a qualitative approach based on structured interviews and employed the content analysis methodology for interpretation. The findings of the research questions revealed that, for the most part, globalization has, in fact, positively impacted individuals' cultural identities and lives. The positive effect of globalization appeared in the form of increased education and employment opportunities and increased open-mindedness regarding cultural diversity. The study also rejected that the world has become more homogenized, but rather that globalization has opened the doors to the enhancement of cultures.

Keywords: globalization, culture, identity, immigrants.

Introduction

The increase of international movements across borders has revolutionized the world and increased the interdependency between nations. Different cultures and societies have learned to deal with one another to benefit from new growth opportunities to increase their wealth. Moreover, economic integration has led to the emergence of borderless global markets, significantly contributing to the world's gross domestic product. On the one hand, this movement has proven to be economically prosperous. However, on the other hand, one cannot disregard the adverse side effects.

Although this is a centuries-old phenomenon, it has now become one of the most critical issues of our time. Research recently started examining which aspects of the current wave are being impacted. While some of the most noticeable effects of this

movement revolve around the economy and environment, more and more works are starting to notice its impact on cultural identity.

With the increased migration linked to labor, people are now forced to adapt to new environments, which most often than not signifies learning new languages and adapting to the new culture to fit in. During that process, one's cultural identity can be altered and more importantly, this will directly impact their children's cultural identities and those of their descendants, too.

This research aims to analyze the real impact that globalization has on the cultural identities of individuals and on other aspects of their lives. More specifically, this research focuses on the journey of a sample from the first and second-generation of immigrants from 21 different countries. It aims to determine if globalization is leading to the homogenization of cultures. By doing so, it seeks to investigate the cause and effect relationship between this phenomenon and cultural identities.

1. Theoretical Background

1.1. Globalization

Marius-Razvan Surugiu and Camelia Surugiu (2015) described globalization as the drive behind the current international integration and global economic growth, which led to increased interdependence between countries. They further defined it as a complex process that enabled the development of communication and which increased the investment expansion as well as the cross-border flows of goods and services. Moreover, it has been described by François Bourguignon as the economic openness that decreased transportation costs and increased foreign direct investment (Howes 2018). Inarguably, this representation of globalization predominantly focuses on the economic dimension which has transformed the societies we know today. Simply put, globalization is indirectly and directly measured by its quantitative contribution to the world rather than its qualitative impact on individuals and societies.

While this new economic interdependence may seem favorable, according to Friedmann (2005), this poses an issue. Since the focus has shifted on economic relations, this tends to render invisible the real effects of globalization on people's daily lives. In fact, Samimi and Jenatabadi (2014) approached this concept from a cause-effect perspective and explained that globalization is a complicated process that impacts different aspects of life. Amongst these are economic growth, poverty, inequality, the environment, and cultural dominance. Hence, this approach allows considering both the positive and negative ramifications caused by this phenomenon and encourages reflecting on the future.

Another essential aspect to consider is history (Shestova and Ariskina 2020). Several historians believe globalization first started in the late fifteenth century triggered by two particular events: Christopher Columbus's arrival in America in 1492 and Vasco da Gama's arrival in India in 1498. Trade expansion is the mothership which gave rise to globalization (O'Rourke and Williamson 2002).

1.2. Culture and Cultural Identity

According to the Oxford English Dictionary, culture is a set of 'ideas, customs, and social behavior of a particular people or society.'

Oyserman *et al.* (2012) explained that identities are 'the traits and characteristics, social relations, roles and social group memberships that define who one is.' According

to this work, identities orient individuals in life and provide them with a 'meaning-making lens' to assess the world. It elaborates on the principle that one's identity can be focused on the past, the present, and the future. This approach leads to the understanding that identities can change over time. Since part of the identities is heavily based on culture, cultural identities can therefore change. Cultural identity has become the cornerstone of national identity and an individual's cultural identity consists of two parts: 1) the identity of the nation to which the individual belongs to and 2) its multi-dimensional character. The multi-dimensional nature relates to internal psychological processes such as the attitudes, cognitions, and emotions of a specific group. It is the construction of the cultural identity embodied both in a social environment and at individual level.

1.3. Biculturalism

Seth J. Schwartz and Jennifer B. Unger (2010) explained that biculturalism has been defined in many ways but most commonly it refers to an individual with a cultural identity composed of one's heritage culture and the culture of the country in which he or she has settled or was born in. For instance, children of immigrants, although they are born into a different culture, they are still embedded with the cultural heritage of their parents and family. It is important to note that this concept can also apply to individuals living in ethnic enclaves, geographic areas with high ethnic concentration.

Furthermore, biculturalism focuses primarily on individuals' cultural behaviors, such as the language spoken, the choice of surroundings, and other preferences (Schwartz and Unger 2010). From this standpoint, individuals would be classified as bicultural if they speak both the host country's language and the language of their cultural heritage. Also, since this concept is based on behaviors, this would mean that biculturalism implies more than just the language, as it is linked to one's values.

Moreover, Schwartz and Unger (2010) explained that individuals will adapt their behavior based on who they interact with. They will also develop some coping strategies in order to navigate across both cultures. This behavior demonstrates a high level of flexibility and adaptation.

On the other hand, biculturalism also opens the door to intragroup marginalization. According to Castillo *et al.* (2007) intragroup marginalization is defined as 'the perceived interpersonal distancing by members of the heritage culture when an individual displays cultural characteristics of the dominant group.' It is the perception of rejection from people of the individual's heritage culture due to not conforming to the prescribed values and expectations. Rejection can cause interpersonal conflicts regarding one's own identity. Therefore, there are both advantages and disadvantages at being bicultural.

1.4. Impact of Globalization on Cultural Identity

On the positive impacts, globalization has reduced the stereotyping and misconceptions about other individuals and different cultures. People now have instant access to worldwide information from any location globally, hence it is easier to become more knowledgeable and get a better understanding of foreign values and attitudes. Moreover, Dimova and Gillen (2017) pointed out that while many individuals associate globalization with the uniformity of cultural identities, this also creates a counter-demand

for authenticity, which then becomes a valuable asset on the global market. In other words, people will steer away from homogenization.

Not all good cultural practices were born in one civilization and societies have taught and corrected one another to progress in the right direction. Cultural differences and different ideologies are essential for the advancement of civilization. Exchange of thoughts and comparison need to take place for one to re-evaluate his or her choices and decisions. Societies have become larger in recent decades due to their acceptance and welcoming of people from different backgrounds. Consequently, this created a whole new culture of its own (Wani 2011).

Additionally, Yi Wang (2007) explained that globalization actually enhanced cultural identity. From this author's point of view, the welcoming of new cultures has enabled individuals to become more self-aware of cultural identities than before. Globalization could lead to a sense of 'togetherness' rather than homogenization. Globalization could be seen as the enabler behind cultural identities. In other words, thanks to technology, there is extensive and accessible information about different cultures, and people can now learn and educate themselves without necessarily traveling.

Furthermore, according to the United States Census Bureau, there has been a growth-rate of almost 3 per cent in interracial marriages in the US since 2000, and this rate is expected to increase over the upcoming years (Rico *et al.* 2018). These unions could signify the increase of potential multicultural children which would mean that these individuals would be exposed to different cultures within the same household.

While it may seem that globalization predominantly impacts the economy and the environment, other important aspects need to be acknowledged. Jensen *et al.* (2011) determined that first-hand and indirect interactions with people from diverse cultures are continually increasing, mainly due to various media. This has made it more difficult for individuals to develop a cultural identity of their own. A person can identify with two or more cultures, and his or her identity will depend on individual choices. Following this rationality, a question that could be raised is whether another culture's adoption takes away from one's native culture. For example, if an individual decides to adopt certain Western culture values, does this mean that he or she need to let go of some of his or her current values?

Atuma Okpara and Edwin Agwu (2015) also emphasized the negative impacts of globalization. In particular, they mentioned that when people are moving in and out of countries, they tend to adapt to the prominent culture of that new country. In other words, they will embrace and follow foreign cultures and forsake their own roots. This cultural adjustment could lead to a rise in cultural conflicts and a loss of cultural identity.

Thilini Ferdinando (2015) stressed that with the advancement of science and technology, the world is getting increasingly globalized, and we are slowly witnessing a loss of diversity. Languages are changing into simpler and faster mode of communication and there is an increase of English incorporation (Sarwal 2019). For example, in the Sinhala language, spoken mainly in Sri Lanka, many words were substituted by English words. Hence, this native language has undergone drastic changes and is slowly shifting towards the English language. In the same light, UNESCO shared that between 1950 and 2010, over 230 languages went extinct (Moseley 2010). Furthermore, National Geographic explained that every two weeks another language dies (Strochlic 2018).

Overall, the authors above made it clear that globalization has made the cultural identity development process more difficult, as individuals are conflicted between two

or more cultures. Also, native languages seem to be shifting towards business languages and are also being deprioritized to make room for more 'important' languages. Finally, globalization has an impact on global citizenship identification (Reysen *et al.* 2020).

1.5. Globalization and Racism

According to Bosworth *et al.* (2008) racism is very much still alive in this day and age, and globalization might be an important factor behind it. Visible ethnic minorities will suffer the most from this, which will cause serious trauma in the long term. Mistreatment and alienization can push these individuals to feel detached from their host country and its culture. Hence, this could lead to potentially dangerous situations. The authors linked globalization to the higher likelihood of crimes and increased racism.

Idowu *et al.* (2019) and Weisskopf (2009) also elaborated on the influence of globalization on the discrimination against people on account of their ethnic group identity. While this is an age-old phenomenon, globalization today is contributing to the growth of ethnicity-based discrimination and that it is progressing faster than ever before. It is plausible to believe that there is a higher likelihood for discrimination, given that we encounter more people from different backgrounds and cultures.

1.6. The Impact of Globalization on the Economy and Education

Globalization has contributed to the increase in the gross domestic product in developing countries and resulted in advancements in health indicators, such as life expectancy. Globalization of technology and information is expected to reduce the inequalities in public health interventions between the rich and the poor. Hence, it is undeniable that the world has greatly benefited from globalization on many levels. More and more developing countries are committed to overcoming the development gaps and are aligned to enhance their economic performance every day. Moreover, multilateral trade rules have been set to ensure that the products meet specific safety and health standards thanks to international trade hence providing people with better product quality overall (Ebrahim *et al.* 2007; Agwu and Okpara 2015; Komlosy 2019).

Notably, there are evident economic and educational opportunities arising from companies moving towards developing countries to acquire labor forces and the enabling of business expansion through the advancement of technology (Agwu and Okpara 2015). People can now work and get educated from anywhere in the world. Globalization has unraveled free movement of capital, communication, and transportation. It is accurate to say that many people now have direct access to real-time information in this day and age. Not to mention that the access to information and data has enabled societies to educate themselves and make sounder and more informed decisions.

Furthermore, over the years, the percentage of international students has significantly increased, positively contributing to the countries' gross domestic product. During the period 2014–2015, the international students contributed to £10.8 bn of UK export earnings, and also due to their spending expenditure, this generated 206,600 jobs.

In conjunction with both the economy and education, there has been a decrease in the low-skilled labor force in many countries, therefore creating a more competitive labor market. It is also important to mention that other important factors, such as people no longer retiring at 65, more women in the workforce, and technology, have also played an essential role in increasing market competitiveness.

Worldwide, there has been a substantial decrease in the number of people without education between 1990 and 2010. For example, if we look at China and Brazil, both these countries had a 20 % to 40 % share of the population, 15 years and older, with no education. Two decades later, that percentage decreased to 0 % to 20 % which is significant considering that these two nations represented 22 % of the total population in 2010 (World Bank 2019a, 2019b).

The average number of years of total schooling across all education levels for the population aged 25 years and over has significantly increased in the period 1990–2017. For instance, India went from zero to three years of education, on average, to six to nine years. Considering that India holds the record for the second-highest population globally (1.339B in 2017), that is once again, a powerful impact.

Agwu and Okpara (2015) also report that while globalization has opened new venues, such as wider and diversified markets, this has dramatically impacted the local and national markets. When companies decide to establish their manufacturing plants in foreign countries for cheaper labor, the host countries generally tend to generate fewer revenues, and most of the profits go to foreign companies. Thus, once again, creating a disparity between economies.

Masteikiene and Venckuviene (2015) claimed that amongst the many unavoidable negative impacts of globalization is the growing political power of multinational corporations, which consequently led to the devastating overexploitation of human labor and natural resources in emerging markets. It also led to a massive loss of jobs in developed countries.

2. Empirical Study

2.1. Research Questions, Methodological Approach and Research Design

Based on the above literature review and analysis, we put forward the following two research questions:

- To what extent has globalization impacted first and second generation immigrants' cultural identities and lives?
- Is globalization homogenizing all cultures and slowly dissolving different cultural identities of the first and second-generation immigrants?

To answer these questions, structured interviews were conducted with a total of 32 participants from the first and second-generation immigrants. Initially, the focus of this research was exclusively the second-generation immigrants with the aim of analyzing their experiences as children of immigrants and the impacts of growing up in a different cultural setting. However, given that the challenges and impacts faced by the second generation of immigrants could differ entirely from those faced by the first generation of immigrants, dismissing the first generation would narrow down the results of this research. Moreover, first-generation immigrants needed to be included in the sample in order to truly understand the motives and aspirations behind their decision of moving abroad. Additionally, due to globalization, many individuals would in fact be part of both the first and second generation immigrants and their outlook and experiences would be invaluable to this work. Therefore, the sample included both first and second-generation immigrants.

This approach allowed exploring and conceptualizing every individual's perspective and journey. More importantly, it allowed comparing and contrasting the perspectives

from the two different generations regarding globalization. It also provided an insight into these individuals' decisions when choosing to raise their children abroad. In total, 32 participants between the ages of 22 and 61, from 21 different countries, were interviewed.

Table 1

Demographics of participants

Countries (21)	# of participants from 1 st Generation	# of participants from 2 nd Generation	# of participants from both the 1 st and 2 nd Generation	Total	Age range
Algeria	–	1	1	2	26–27
Andorra	1	–	–	1	29
Cameroon	–	1	–	1	20
Canada	2	9	–	11	24–61
China	–	1	–	1	27
Colombia	–	1	1	2	28
France	1	–	1	2	26
Germany	2	1	1	4	22–36
Guatemala	–	1	–	1	34
India	–	1	2	3	24
Iran	–	–	1	1	33
Italy	1	2	–	3	26
Mauritius	1	–	–	1	25
Mexico	–	1	–	1	30
Morocco	4	3	1	8	24–61
Netherlands	1	2	–	3	26–28
Pakistan	–	1	1	2	26–32
Saudi Arabia	1	–	–	1	27
Spain	1	–	1	2	26–29
South Africa	1	–	–	1	31
United Kingdom	–	1	–	1	30
Total	16	26	10	52	22–61

At first, it was planned to set in place face-to-face interviews. However, given the circumstances revolving around the COVID-19 pandemic, this was not possible and the interviews were held via videoconference, between April and September 2020.

The interviews were structured with a pre-defined set of questions. Two different interview scripts were produced, one for the first-generation immigrants and the other for the second-generation immigrants. They were recorded on the computer from the

videoconference software used in each case, and then transcribed to a Word for Windows file. In the event of any gap or unclear information, participants were re-contacted for clarification. All the interviews lasted between 20 minutes to 70 minutes, with an average of 30 minutes and 21 seconds.

While most of the interviews were conducted in English, some of the respondents were French natives and preferred to respond in French. Their answers were translated to English and any accuracy concerns were discussed with a professional translator.

Table 2

Coded Questions (Close-ended), the first generation of immigrants

Question	=1	=2	=3
Did you have any children when you first immigrated? If not, do you have children now?	1= had or have children	2= no children then, no children now	n/a
How easy or hard was it to adjust to a new country? (Cultural shock)	1= easy to adjust	2=not easy to adjust	3= hard at first then easy
Did you learn any new languages after immigrating?	1= yes, learnt a new language	2= no, did not learn a new language	n/a
Why did you decide to immigrate to another country? Why did you choose that country specifically?	1= for better opportunities	2= other reason	n/a
What do you consider yourself (and your children)? (<i>i.e.</i> , nationality wise)	1= new nationality	2= native nationality	3= both nationalities
How important is it for you that your children speak your native language? Given the choice between having them learn your native language or a business language such as English or Mandarin, what would you choose?	1= business language over native	2= native language over business language	3=both native and business languages
How important is it for you to keep your cultural heritage alive?	1= not important	2=important	n/a
How has <i>globalization</i> impacted your culture?	1= positively	2=negatively	3= both positively and negatively
Do you feel that immigrating to a new country has given you more opportunities in life? For your children?	1= yes	2=no	3=unsure
Do you feel that moving to a new country has had an effect on your values?	1=yes	2=no	3=unsure

Table 2 (continued)

Question	=1	=2	=3
How was it (if) when you returned home for the first time?	1= no cultural shock	2=cultural shock	3=somewhat of a cultural shock
Overall, do you have positive or negative feelings in regard to <i>globalization</i> ?	1=positive	2=negative	3=both positive and negative
If you could go back in time, would you do anything different? (E.g.: Choose a new country, raise your children differently, etc.)	1= no	2=yes	3= yes and no
Do you ever plan on moving back to your native country someday?	1=no	2=yes	3=maybe

Table 3

Coded Questions (Close-ended), the second generation of immigrants

Question	=1	=2	=3
Can you speak other languages other than your native language?	1= can speak native language and other languages	2= can only speak native language	3= does not speak native language, only other languages
What do you consider yourself (and your children if any)? (i.e.: nationality wise)	1= new nationality	2= native nationality	3= both nationalities
How important is it for you to speak your parents' native language?	1= not important	2=important	3= indifferent
How important is it for you to keep your cultural heritage alive?	1= not important	2=important	3= indifferent
Do you feel that some of your values stem from your parents' culture?	1=no	2= yes	3= unsure
How has <i>globalization</i> impacted your life and culture?	1= positively	2= negatively	3=both positively and negatively
Do you feel that your parents' decision to move abroad has given you more opportunities in life?	1= yes, more opportunities	2=no	3= unsure
Did you ever visit your parents' native country?	1=no	2=yes	3=n/a
Did you experience a culture shock when visiting your parents' native country?	1= yes	2=no	3=somewhat of a cultural shock
Were there challenges growing up as a child of immigrant parents?	1=no challenges	2= many challenges	n/a
Overall, do you have positive or negative feelings in regard to <i>globalization</i> ?	1= positive	2=negative	3= both positive and negative
Do you ever plan on moving to another country?	1=yes	2=no	3=maybe

2.2. Data Analysis

Content analysis was used to code and categorize the data into themes. The interviews were open coded to categorize key themes and eventually identify patterns. First, transcripts were read and re-read for situation purposes. Then labeling the relevant pieces was conducted by highlighting relevant words and phrases as well as recurring words. Given that the interviews were structured and that the questions were identical for participants from the same group, the questions were initially used to create the categories and then the relevant codes were grouped into each category. Once this was done, code-filtering was performed by eliminating the irrelevant and repetitive codes. Combining one or more codes together was also done. Once the codes were finalized, categories were reviewed to ensure that there was a clear and distinct relationship between the two. Then a description of the connection between the codes and categories was written. Lastly, no hierarchy or higher importance between the themes was established.

2.3. Results

When first and second generations of immigrants were asked if they believed globalization had positively impacted their cultural identities, close to 72 per cent of the participants said yes. The most repetitive answers revolved around the notion that globalization had enabled them to grow in a multicultural environment which in return positively impacted their relationships and allowed them to learn new languages. Moreover, the majority of participants conveyed that the opportunity to grow up in a multicultural environment had allowed them to become more open-minded and respectful towards other cultures. Not to mention that, a noticeable pattern indicated that many individuals retained their native cultural identity and further embraced parts of foreign cultures.

In contrast, while the remaining 28 per cent also agreed that globalization had positively impacted their culture, they explained that there had been some negative impacts as well. More specifically, they explained that they had lost part of their cultural identities over time while immersing themselves in the new culture.

Additionally, there was a unanimous agreement amongst the first-generation immigrant participants that immigrating abroad had separated them from their families, which negatively impacted their lives and mental health for many years.

Regarding the interviewees' overall feelings on globalization, it seems that more than the majority of the interviewees (69 %) pointed out at least one negative aspect. Amongst these were the following: loss of culture, deterioration of our planet, the dependence of nations, and unrealistic benchmark.

The first-generation immigrants were asked if they had learnt a new language after immigrating. 84 per cent of them had learned a new language, while the remaining 16 per cent had not.

Then, when interviewees from the first generation of immigrants were asked the following question: 'Given the choice between having your children learn your native language or a business language such as English or Mandarin, what would you choose?', 83.3 per cent of them answered that they would favor both the native language and the other language(s), which would allow their kids to have more employment opportunities in the future. On the other hand, only 16.7 per cent of the candidates chose the native language over the business language.

Moreover, when the second generation immigrant participants were asked which languages they could speak, 100 per cent of them declared that they could speak both their parents' native language(s) and new languages. Hence, indicating that native languages have not been impacted.

In addition, when the participants of the first generation immigrant were asked if they had experienced a cultural shock when they returned home for the first time, at least 42 per cent of them said yes. On the other hand, many of the remaining participants explained that the cultural shock happened many years later, once they got used to their host environment.

Also, 100 per cent of the first-generation immigrant participants claimed that maybe someday they would want to move back to their country of origin.

Another repetitive theme that surfaced during the interviews is the challenges faced by the second-generation immigrants. When the interviewees were asked if they had experienced challenges growing up as children of immigrants in a different society, every single participant but one claimed that they did. A common pattern of lack of belonging was detected amongst most of the participants. Furthermore, many of them claimed that their parents were very conservative, which consequently made the whole process much harder.

When first and second generation of immigrants were asked if they believed that globalization had given them more opportunities in life, the results revealed that 100 per cent of the candidates, from both generations, believed that moving abroad had increased their life opportunities. The most repetitive answers revolved around the opportunities linked to education and career.

There was an agreement amongst all the participants from the first-generation immigrants concerning the increase in job opportunities abroad as well as higher financial incentives. Also, within the same group, those with children explained that one of the main motives for choosing to move overseas was to give their children a better education, which would ensure better employment opportunities in the future. Furthermore, when asked if they wished to go back in time and do anything differently (*e.g.*, choose a different country), none of them said yes.

The second-generation immigrants were also of the opinion that globalization increased their job opportunities, however, their answers largely focused on education. Many of the participants expressed their gratefulness towards their parents and how growing up abroad had positively altered their lives. At least 66 per cent of the people interviewed have studied abroad at least once throughout their education and more than 62 per cent of the interviewees have worked abroad at least once.

Furthermore, both groups explained that living in multicultural societies had allowed them to build an international network which turned out to be fruitful for their careers.

Based on the data gathered for the research question above, there is a clear indication that first and second-generation immigrants have embraced their host country's culture. Having said that, the findings also indicate that there is a strong desire to preserve their cultural heritage, especially for the future generations to come.

One of the first questions of the interview focused on the national identification and imprint on every individual. When participants were asked about what nationality they consider themselves to be, as well as their children, 62.5 per cent of the participants

from the first and second generations acknowledged both nationalities when asked. On the other hand, 34.4 per cent of the participants who answered 'native nationality' only have one nationality; hence that was the only possible answer. Finally, the remainder 3.1 per cent chose the 'new nationality' over their native one. Therefore, all the participants with dual citizenship owned up to both nationalities.

Moreover, when both groups of participants were asked about the importance of preserving their cultural heritage, most interviewees reported that it was crucial to preserve the cultural heritage for the future generations to come. Many of them expressed a strong sense of pride in regard to their traditions, language and most importantly history. A common pattern revolved around the ideology that we are living in a fast-changing world and it is up to us to protect and uphold our culture. Likewise, almost all the participants admitted that globalization had not changed their values.

2.4. Discussion

The research demonstrated that there is a cause-effect relationship between globalization and cultural identity. Additionally, based on the sample studied, the data suggests that the benefits associated to globalization have outweighed the negative ramifications. More specifically immigrants have positively benefited from globalization in terms of their education and employment opportunities, as well as languages. Also, globalization gave birth to multiculturalism, which in return has proven to be highly enriching for these individuals in terms of their open-mindedness and overall knowledge.

Furthermore, while the literature review proved that globalization is in fact slowly homogenizing all the cultures, more precisely, in terms of languages, the analysis does not completely support that claim. The results from the interview clearly demonstrated that at this stage, all the participants have retained their native language and have also learned new languages. Moreover, the majority of the participants clearly indicated that their values and native culture has not disappeared, rather, they have also embraced parts of other cultures.

Having said that, it is important to mention the negative ramifications associated to globalization. The most common theme was associated to the cultural shocks and challenges faced by both the first and second-generation immigrants.

At the beginning of the research, it was hypothesized that if nothing changes, globalization will slowly homogenize most cultures, leading to a loss of cultural identity. The results gathered from the interviews mainly indicated the opposite. Individuals exhibited the retention of their values and cultural characteristics, as well as the desire to preserve that legacy for future generations to come. It was also predicted that due to the increased competitiveness in the job market, students would be encouraged to learn new languages, which in return would mean that they would have to focus on the 'business' languages and deprioritize their native language(s). In that same line of thought, it was believed that parents would often be conflicted in choosing between teaching their kids their native language(s) or teaching them a language that would give them a competitive advantage in the future. The results for this segment were the most shocking. The data completely disproved the original hypothesis. It was expected that many people would not have the ability to speak their parents' native language; however, the opposite was true.

Secondly, the interviews' findings met the expectations in regard to the positive impact of globalization on individuals' education, employment and open-mindedness. Eve-

ry single participant reported that they had positively benefited from globalization in terms of their education or careers. Most of them also manifested their increased open-mindedness in regard to other culture and individuals.

Based on this research, globalization has positively impacted individuals' cultural identities. According to the participants, the biggest benefit is their increase of open-mindedness and general knowledge on other cultures. From this perspective, this can positively impact one's relationships with people from different backgrounds, but it can also open their minds to different experiences and improve their lives. For example, an individual may get acquainted with international cuisine or adopt new customs from a different culture. Moreover, based on this research, individuals explained that learning about new cultures did not take away from their own culture; therefore altogether, it has been a gain rather than a loss. For instance, individuals still associate to their native nationalities, but they have now added a new one to their lives.

Most of the first-generation immigrant participants described not experiencing a cultural shock when going back to their countries initially, but that as years passed by, every time they would go back to their home country, the cultural shock would grow. This is a clear indication that globalization is in fact changing the cultural identities of individuals, as their home countries suddenly feel different. Manifestly, one's mentality and ideologies can change over time, especially if the individual in question moved to a different environment.

Another important aspect touched upon was the challenges faced by second generation immigrants. Based on the results, most of the participants felt as though they did not belong and that their parents had conservative views. Interestingly, many participants also further explained that in order to fit in, they would adapt and change their behavior. Evidently, this demonstrated that to a certain extent, that globalization did in fact push people to assimilate and adapt which means that it is impacting their cultural identity and beliefs.

Overall, it is safe to say that both first and second generation immigrants faced some challenges. First, regarding education, it is undeniable that effects of globalization have been profoundly advantageous. It has resulted in teaching methods that are more interconnected and widespread and has enabled students to study in several parts of the world. Both the results of the interviews and the data gathered from previous research have demonstrated that individuals are now exposed to higher education. Nowadays, most universities have partner universities worldwide and offer students the opportunity to study abroad for a semester or two. Subsequently, students are increasingly becoming prepared for multinational roles and the business scene. In fact, over 66 per cent of the participants claimed to have studied abroad at least once.

Moreover, multicultural education has also increased the cultural knowledge and open-mindedness of students. As societies are slowly becoming more multicultural, children are being raised in more open-minded environments, pushing them to understand the individuals around them better. They also develop an eagerness to learn and an appreciation for differences.

Globalization also led to a significant increase in the literacy level globally and average schooling years. Globalization has, without a doubt, positively impacted education.

Lastly, in regard to employment opportunities, both first and second-generation immigrants have agreed that one of the most significant impacts of globalization is the

opening of doors to new markets and workplaces. More than 62 per cent of the interviewees have worked abroad at least once. While these results met the expectations, the number of responses that included the word 'multicultural' when discussing their work experience was nonetheless surprising. Hence there was a clear positive pattern between employment and multicultural environment. Participants explained that working in a multicultural environment enabled them to grow, remain challenged, and learn more about different cultures.

Globalization has undoubtedly maximized diversity within many firms globally. From a business perspective, individuals learn more about cultural differences and can then adapt to the different types of clients. Furthermore, diversity and inclusion create a healthy environment for the workers; hence, employees tend to feel accepted and valued, making them feel happier.

In fact, striking findings showed evidence that the participants feel this sense of pride when talking about their cultural heritage and they expressed their desire to preserve and cultivate their culture for future generations.

Another important aspect that should be touched upon is prejudices and racism. The desire to assimilate or discriminate against another individual may stem from the lack of understanding or knowledge concerning another culture. Individuals born in multicultural environments express fewer prejudices regarding other people because it is their 'normality'. Hence, they will not necessarily attempt to change people. Interestingly, the data gathered from the interview points in the direction that globalization leads to the increase of awareness of different cultures, which broadens one's mind and decreases prejudices and discrimination. One of the common patterns detected was the acceptance of others. Therefore, the results do not support the previous research from the literature review.

2.5. Implications for Cultural Identities

While, on the one hand, previous studies have discussed cultures potentially becoming more homogenized, other studies have discussed the increasing number of bicultural individuals. Once again, as mentioned earlier, in some parts of the world, the interracial marriage rates have increased. Hence, globalization has, without a doubt, increased the number of bicultural people. Naturally, in some specific cases, there is a higher likelihood that specific cultural customs might be abandoned in order to co-exist better within the same household. In cases where children are involved, couples are involuntary or voluntary forced to make mutual decisions in regard to the upbringing of their children. They need to decide what they will teach their children and what part of their culture they wish to incorporate when raising them.

In different circumstances, this can, in fact, increase one's flexibility and resilience. Of course, everyone has a different outlook when it comes to what a person from a certain culture should be like or behave like. Due to this, certain people might choose to reject or not associate with a bi-cultural person. Consequently, a bicultural individual can feel as though they do not fully belong to any cultural group and feel conflicted about their identity. As explained by Castillo *et al.* (2007), this thought process can often be associated to intragroup marginalization. In other words, this is the experience of rejecting one's heritage culture. Therefore, being bicultural can have both advantages and disadvantages.

Moreover, cultural identities and diversity make the world so great and unique. Looking back on history, many cultures have been wiped out by globalization, technology and the rapidly changing economic landscape. For instance, as mentioned above by National Geographic, every two weeks a language goes extinct. Therefore, there is no argument that cultural identity is at risk.

As proven by this research, there are numerous advantages in globalization and its impacts on languages, such as the retention of native languages and learning of new languages. So, one can help but wonder the actual implications of the disappearance of cultural identities and its impact on societies. As more and more individuals prioritize business languages to increase their education and employment opportunities, the risk of language extinction increases. At this rate, more languages will go extinct and many more will become endangered.

Thus, efforts and actions will be needed to preserve different cultures and diversity over time. Thankfully, we live in an era of technology where everything can be stored and saved.

Overall, cultural identities will continue to be effected as long as globalization progresses in the same direction. It will be up to each individual to decide if they want to preserve their culture and pass it on to the future generations to come.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this research aimed to determine the impacts of globalization on cultural identities, more specifically to understand whether this phenomenon is leading to homogenization of cultures on the first and second generation immigrants.

Initially, it was hypothesized that globalization would lead to homogenization of culture as well as to disappearance of native languages. Furthermore, it was also expected that this movement would positively impact education and employment opportunities as well as increase the open-mindedness of individuals.

Given the nature of this research, an interview-based approach within a qualitative methodology would enable to better understand the real impacts of globalization on cultural and a more in-depth understanding of each individual's journey.

Interestingly, not all the results matched the expectations. Based primarily on qualitative analysis, results concluded that the cultural identities of the sample studied were not negatively impacted by globalization or homogenized. The majority of participants preserved their values and culture despite living in a foreign country. Most of the participants were determined to protect their cultural heritage in order to pass it on to the future generations. Moreover, there was a definite positive impact on languages. Once again, all the participants claimed to be able to speak their native languages and also learned new ones.

By analyzing each individual's immigration journey, this research has shown that globalization has in fact positively impacted most of the participants' cultural identities. It has increased their open-mindedness as well as cultural knowledge, therefore improving cross-cultural communications. Not to mention that their multicultural environment has allowed them to perform better in school and in their workplace. Also, many individuals clearly explained that globalization has actually enhanced their cultural identities since they can choose to adopt the best characteristics of each culture.

Nonetheless, as mentioned throughout, there is clear evidence based on previous research that globalization can in fact lead to the loss of cultural identity. This research also discussed about a few outliers which indicated that globalization can negatively impact one's cultural identity. While globalization may have not negatively impacted these individuals' cultural identities, it does not mean that it cannot happen in the future.

Lastly, this research opens the door for further studies on the enhancing of globalization on cultural identities rather than its potential homogenization. Based on the sample interviewed, the conclusion is that globalization could, in fact, be beneficial for cultures, especially in this day and age where technology enables us to store and preserve the evidence of different cultures. Also, globalization could completely redefine the ideology behind 'cultural identity', whereas cultural identity would become 'multicultural identity'. Individuals could decide to embrace specific characteristics of different cultures, rather than just one.

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Introduction to The Monstrous Global: the Effects of Globalization on Cultures

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Ju Young Jin and Jae H. Roe,

"Introduction to The Monstrous Global: The Effects of Globalization on Cultures"

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Abstract: This special issue on "The Monstrous Global: The Effects of Globalization on Cultures" explores representations of the monstrous effects and products of globalization. The monstrous (as in *The Monstrous Feminine* by Barbara Creed) in this sense alludes to the ways in which local or national displays of fear and anxiety about the Other are embedded in struggles and tensions of global scale; the inability to cognitively map the effect of such global forces on local/national problems produces monstrous representations of the global. Global forces such as neoliberalism and reactionary nationalism, technology, climate change, migration and displacement lead to accelerating instability and proliferating problems without local solutions, thus leading to growing fear and anger in search of targets. The term "monstrous" also implies that the unruly and uncontrollable forces of globalization can generate zones of undecidability that can precipitate formations of new identity and solidarity across race, class, and gender. This special issue is organized around monsters, both symbolic and literal, whose representation makes visible the changes, anxieties, and political responses generated by invisible global forces.

Ju Young JIN and Jae H. ROE

Introduction to The Monstrous Global: The Effects of Globalization on Cultures

Globalization is a process that cannot be explained and understood by any one theory. In every location, global forces interact with different economic conditions, political structures, cultural traditions, historical continuities and discontinuities, etc. The result of these interactions is what we call globalization. A comparative approach to representations of globalization would investigate the ways in which texts that depict specific locations reveal such interactions and geographically, culturally, historically specific forms of globalization. The term "globalization" tends to conjure an image of something colossal and immeasurable, a totalizing force that connects and integrates people across nations; yet the concept is also placeless and deterritorialized in the sense that it refers not to a specific place but to abstract conditions and processes. Understood as a dematerialized space of transnational interactions and cultural flows, or "cyberspace" (Jameson 154) as Fredric Jameson calls it, the global becomes a monstrous abstraction. The monstrous in this sense alludes to the ways in which local or national displays of fear and anxiety about the Other are embedded in struggles and tensions of global scale; the inability to cognitively map the effects of such global forces on local/national problems produces monstrous representations of the global. Global forces such as neoliberalism and reactionary nationalism, technology, climate change, migration and displacement lead to accelerating instability and proliferating problems without local solutions, thus leading to growing fear and anger in search of targets. On the other hand, the term "monstrous" also implies that the unruly and uncontrollable forces of globalization generate zones of instability and fluidity in which formations of new identity and solidarity across divisions such as race, class, and gender can emerge. Ironically, then, globalization can also produce spaces for marginalized groups to contest dominant discourses and the limitations imposed by local traditions and political structures.

The monstrous global is an organizing theme for this special issue exploring the effects of globalization as the uncontrollable and unruly forces that disrupt and defy boundaries and borders as well as produce fear and fascination at the same time. Inspired by Barbara Creed's coinage of the term "monstrous-feminine," which is meant to highlight "the importance of gender in the construction of...monstrosity" (Creed 3), the monstrous global seeks to delineate the ways in which globalization plays a pivotal role in configuring or animating monstrous effects in sociocultural terrains across the globe. The essays included in this special issue explore, from various disciplinary perspectives, representations of the monstrous effects and products of globalization. The texts analyzed in the essays, ranging from art and literature to film and television, locate globalization in specific geographies, histories, and sociopolitical contexts. The analysis of these texts offers new perspectives on the anxieties produced by global forces and the politics of resentment produced by the failure to cognitively map such forces, but also on the potential for local populations or marginalized groups within those populations to utilize the effects of globalization to refashion individual and collective identities. Because globalization is a complex, evolving, and deterritorialized process that seems intangible and impossible to map but has profound material consequences, specific cultural texts and localized phenomena must be explored to make the uneven and destabilizing effects of globalization visible. This special issue is organized around monsters, both symbolic and literal, whose representation makes visible the changes, anxieties, and political responses generated by invisible global forces.

In *Monsters of the Market: Zombies, Vampires and Global Capitalism*, David McNally argues that the monsters proliferating in popular culture today are historical products of capitalism, and that their global proliferation is symptomatic of the increasingly global reach of the destabilizing effects of, and anxieties caused by, capitalism. He illustrates how Marx used "the language of monstrosity" (McNally 15); Marx believed that such language is the most effective and also most accurate way to describe capitalism because it is, quite literally, "a monstrous system" (McNally 3). Monsters give concrete form to a system whose workings are so complex and contradictory that people often cannot grasp how it affects them or envision how they can affect it. McNally uses examples from literature and popular culture to demonstrate how stories about monsters like vampires and zombies "have appeared at a number of compelling moments in the global rise of capitalism" (McNally 16). In the contemporary moment, the stories that most directly and evocatively depict the monstrous effects of, and anxieties about, global capitalism are coming from Africa; McNally introduces mythic stories set in modern Africa in which credit cards "provide instant commodities without registering debt," coins "turn people into zombies," and currencies "leave cash-registers and return to their owners after every purchase" (McNally 176). And Marx's vampire appears as "a man who acquires riches after sacrificing his wife and drinking her blood"

(McNally 176). Obviously, such stories are more likely to be produced in environments where the workings of capitalism, and the ways in which capitalism affects interpersonal relationships and communities, "are still experienced as strange and horrifying" (McNally 2); the power of money and credit cards are more likely to be imagined as magical in societies where the destructiveness of their power can still surprise. And Marx's vampire is more likely to return in societies where the destabilizing effects of global capitalism are experienced as a pervasive and tangible violation; in countries where "seventy percent of the people live below the poverty-threshold" and where "life-expectancy" (McNally 221) keeps falling while the presence of global corporations keeps growing, it is not too surprising that people can imagine those corporations sucking their blood and demanding rituals of human sacrifice.

The economist Chris Harman argues that the global economy has become "a zombie system" (Harman 12). With the expansion of global networks of increasingly deregulated financial transactions, and the development of increasingly sophisticated technologies and complex profit-generating formulas, "all sorts of speculative, non-productive activities flourished" to the point where the global economy is reduced to "a mass of capital wandering around the world looking for any opportunity where...there might be profits to be made" (Harman 283). This is a zombie system that has ceased to have any productive function; any growth in the global economy comes not from "processes of production" but from financial speculation involving "chains of lending and borrowing" so complicated that investors at one end of the chain may not "have the remotest idea where interest [is] coming from at the other end" (Harman 286). And once such deregulated and reckless speculation has taken over the global economy, it cannot be stopped, no matter how un-productive and self-destructive it becomes. Governments are inextricably involved in these chains and cannot do more than provide "life support systems...to keep the system from complete collapse" (Harman 326), as when the U.S. government bailed out financial institutions like Lehman Brothers and AIG in 2008 to prevent national and international economic collapse; this is when economists and journalists started using the term "zombie banks" to refer to financial institutions "incapable of fulfilling any positive function" (Harman 12) but kept alive artificially by the government. Harman extends this analogy to the overall economic system to which those banks contribute; like zombies mindlessly overrunning everything, global capitalism is a "runaway system" that cannot be regulated no matter how destructive it becomes, even if it threatens "the very possibility of sustaining human life on Earth" (Harman 328). Zombies appeared everywhere during this period, not just in American popular culture but globally, in apocalyptic narratives about people turning into monsters and destroying their own communities and societies.

Zombie narratives are also stories about walls. In *The Walking Dead*, for example, Rick Grimes is excited to find an abandoned prison; it appears to be a maximum security prison that has a guard tower and is surrounded, twice, by very high fences. It is, as Rick says, "perfect." The series began in 2010, in the aftermath of the financial crisis that led to terminology like "zombie banks" and growing economic insecurity and anxieties about the future. Like the survivors in zombie narratives, desperately trying to keep out the zombies overrunning and destroying everything, many people rely on walls for protection or to feel protected, as Wendy Brown illustrates in *Walled States, Waning Sovereignty*. The walls that countries build, or that politicians promise to build, "respond in terms of both state policies and the anxieties of their subjects to a growing lawlessness lapping at the edges of nation-states and streaming across them" (Brown 83); the more anxieties people feel and the less control their governments seem to have over the global forces that produce their anxieties, the more they support such wall-building. No wall can be built that would keep out the global forces that affect their lives and communities, but the actual wall is less important than the psychological protection that it provides; the walls that have been built or promised in recent years are symbolic and psychological walls that "contain" fears and anxieties produced by "an increasingly unbounded and uncontrollable global order" (Brown 118) and provide an "illusion" (Brown 133) of protection and security. The danger of these walls is that they also produce or reinforce "a collective ethos and subjectivity that is defensive, parochial, nationalistic, and militarized" (Brown 40), because they "cannot block out without shutting in" (Brown 42). This is why the prison in *The Walking Dead* is a perfect symbol of the consequences of relying on psychological walls. The only way to keep out the destructive forces that we are afraid of is to shut ourselves off from the world outside, as the double fences of the prison are designed to do; the fears that we want to contain become a wall that reinforces our fears and our sense of fundamental difference from those that we want to keep out, who increasingly become reduced to monsters. This reaction to the destabilizing effects of globalization is another aspect of the monstrous global, a reactionary nationalism that seeks to restore stability and economic security by identifying targets to blame and promising a return to "an idealized past" (Brown 133) that requires the exclusion of, and directly or indirectly promotes violence against, those who are targeted.

From African stories about the magical powers of money to enslave individuals or control their destinies to American television shows about survivors of a global catastrophe building and defending walls to keep out the monsters destroying the world or to keep themselves from turning into those monsters, we can see the wide range of representations of the monstrous global. These representations show us that globalization is a phenomenon experienced differently in different geopolitical locations and therefore produce different anxieties and responses as well. While many Africans may be experiencing daily the visible and tangible ways in which the economic growth promised by globalization means money leaving their pockets and their communities and accumulating in transnational corporations and banks, many Americans may not see or feel the global forces that produce their economic insecurity and anxieties. Consequently, workers in Africa may identify with characters who have to sacrifice their own families to gain favor from monsters that are draining their blood and destroying their communities, whereas workers in the U.S. may identify with characters trying to protect their families and communities from forces that they cannot understand by building walls that they know cannot save them and defending those walls as long as they can from the monsters accumulating outside. In such ways, monster narratives reflect the anxieties produced by globalization and envision ways to resist the forces of globalization. Even if resistance turns out to be futile, the monsters of these proliferating narratives make visible the destructiveness and expansion of global forces and the local/national variations of the anxieties and political responses generated by such forces. The essays in this special issue provide a comparative analysis of the forms that the monstrous global takes, the anxieties that it produces, and the political consequences of those anxieties.

In "Monstrous Accumulation: Topographies of Fear in an Era of Globalization," Robert Tally, Jr. discusses the increasing popularity of monster narratives in relation to globalization and Marxist theory, and argues that such narratives reflect contemporary anxieties about global capitalism but also help to make visible the processes and effects of globalization, which are increasingly becoming invisible or unknowable. Tally provides an overview of theoretical approaches to this articulation of the monstrous and the global. China Mieville argues that the genre of fantasy envisions the processes of exploitation and reification that are concealed in representations of human experience and historical reality. Jeffrey Jerome Cohen uses the term "Monster Culture" to explain how monsters help us to make sense of our cultures and generate a cognitive map of our social world. Fantasy and monster narratives are symbolic representations that make visible systems too vast to be conceived and global influences too pervasive to be understood. In this way, Tally argues, monsters are fundamentally ideological and simultaneously necessary for ideology-critique; they make possible a political or historical sensibility that makes visible the concrete realities that underlie pervasive anxieties and generalized fears related to globalization. David McNally argues that "the vampire and the zombie are doubles, linked poles of the split society" created by capitalism, and that these monsters of capitalism proliferate and take new forms as the global economy expands and complicates relations of power and renders class struggle nearly invisible. The accumulation of monsters and monster narratives in the era of globalization can be interpreted as an attempt to make sense of, to give concrete form to, global economic forces and the anxieties produced by them. These narratives enable a cognitive mapping that help us to see what seemed invisible and imagine what seemed impossible; even the post-apocalyptic worlds so common in contemporary popular culture serve to clear imaginative space for the possibility of a new global order. Monsters make possible what Tally calls a "fantastic Marxist critique" of a global order that is literally monstrous and makes social change difficult to envision, an alternative vision of critical theory and practice.

In "'The Headwaters of a River of Failure: Detroit as an Icon of American Decline,'" Jae H. Roe analyzes films (*8 Mile*, *Gran Torino*, *It Follows*) and television series (*Hung*, *Low Winter Sun*) that use the setting of Detroit to depict characters who are dealing with deteriorating socioeconomic conditions and whose choices and relationships reflect their difficulties in, and anxieties about, adjusting to such conditions. While the familiar icons of Detroit's decline appear in all of these texts, the narratives evolve from working class realism to satire and ultimately horror, or from anxieties about white working class displacement to the displacement of such anxieties. Roe provides an overview of historical and sociological research that illustrates how Detroit exemplifies the complex ways in which global forces interact with specific socioeconomic conditions and political structures; on the other hand, Roe's analysis of the depictions of Detroit in American popular culture illustrates the difficulty of comprehending the complexity of these problems. The icons of Detroit's decline become simultaneously more recognizable and less graspable, their history evaporating and leaving behind only the vague anxiety and horror evoked by their familiar images. Earlier films like *8 Mile* and *Gran Torino* depict characters who are aware of the racial and class divisions of their city and attempt to adjust to their displacement or overcome their limitations, but the television shows *Hung* and *Low Winter Sun* depict characters whose

resentment reflects white working class anxieties about displacement, without dealing with the histories of race and class relations that produced those anxieties. This historical amnesia culminates in a horror film in which Detroit becomes the source of a monster that can only be referred to as "it," a monstrosity that cannot be explained or contained as it spreads from its "headwaters" (*Hung*) in Detroit. The protagonists of these narratives lose a cognitive map of their lives and their surroundings; the resentment and anxieties reflected in these texts become increasingly volatile and dangerous as the socioeconomic conditions that produce them become more difficult to map and seemingly inescapable.

In "A Thin Line between Sovereign and Abject Agents: Global Action Thrillers with the Sci-Fi Mind-Game War on Terror," Seung-hoon Jeong uses a range of theoretical approaches to analyze how recent Hollywood action and science fiction films, especially *Source Code*, reflect the destabilization and precariousness produced by globalization and neoliberalism. Jeong cites Giorgio Agamben's concept of "homo sacer" and relates it to Julia Kristeva's concept of "abjection," arguing that the global economy produces abject citizens who are denied sociopolitical rights and subjectivity and thus become targets of sovereign violence. In the Jason Bourne films and recent James Bond films, the boundaries between the sovereign (secret) agent and the abject terrorist become increasingly blurred; Jason Bourne, especially, reconstructs himself as what Jeong calls an "abject agent" who resists the institutions of sovereign power that expelled him and the suprallegal violence that they trained him to perform. In *Source Code*, Captain Colter Stevens' mission is to identify a terrorist through a time travel device that repeatedly sends Colter back into the last eight minutes of a passenger (Sean) on the train that was bombed. Colter was killed in Afghanistan, but his brain is connected to the "Source Code" machine; he has to repeat his mission endlessly, and each failure results in his simulated death (in Sean's body). Jeong sees Colter's mission as an allegorical representation of our socioeconomic condition; we are abject agents subjected to data overload and the daily repetition of digital multitasking, and neoliberal globalization has normalized such abjection. To survive until his next death, Colter needs to reboot himself with continuous upgrades, performing temporary work under intense pressure to adjust to unpredictable situations; this is agency reduced to functionality. Colter is allowed a moral victory of sorts by sacrificing himself to save others, but this self-affirmation requires his internalization of the system's values and the value of his function within the system; films like *Source Code* envision a world in which we are trapped in a global system that is both flexible and inescapable, that grants a functional agency that is always at risk of being abjected from a system maintained by productivity and self-regulation.

In "Making the Global Visible: Charting the Uneven Development of Global Monsters in Bong Joon-Ho's *Okja* and Nacho Vigalondo's *Colossal*," Ju Young Jin explores the entanglement of the global and the monstrous in two recent films that position Korea on the cusp between Cold War politics and global capitalism. By using the critical frameworks of postcolonial bildungsroman and Kaiju (Japanese monster films such as Godzilla) genre, Jin demonstrates the ways in which these films stage the broader tensions and radical discontinuities of globalization as well as demystify the notion of "Global Village." The formal disjunction in *Colossal* and *Okja* as evidenced by the two female heroines' modes of projecting the monsters and their uneven development and attainment of Bildung encourage us to view the global in terms of how the legacies of the Cold War and the American century at once interfere with and supplement each other. Analyzing the films with Heidegger's essay "Age of World Picture," Jin illustrates how they make visible the uneven and discontinuous terrains of global capitalism. Gloria in *Colossal* projects a monster in Seoul to counterattack Oscar's monster in small town America which is a trope for the Global Village imaginary. Mija in *Okja* makes a separate peace which is not dissimilar from a preindustrial, pre-globalization fantasy space: a monstrous anomaly outside its locality. Jin contends that Mija shows us a forestalled maturity that serves as an illuminating countercontext to Gloria whose attainment of Bildung is made possible by the agency afforded by her first world privileges. Far from being assimilable to a discourse of Bildung or social integration, Gloria's and Mija's uneven developments show how the effects of globalization code and configure the radical Other, the cast-away: the monsters. It is precisely the system of global capitalism, the appropriation of Korea's physical geography (and the continued occupation of the space of *Okja* and Mija through the pervasive American hegemony), that hinders Mija's ability to achieve Bildung by denying her social agency. Mija occupies a pre-adolescent and pre-industrial pastoral space, a space specifically assigned to her by the logic of U.S. hegemony and global capitalism.

In "Performing the Global: The Mediated Mobility of Virtual Cosmopolitans," Hye Jean Chung examines how contemporary media art and digital technologies can express and actualize desires for global mobility; she analyzes two documentary films, *Born into Brothels* and *City of Photos*, in which marginalized subjects in contemporary India express their desires and imagine themselves as cosmopolitan subjects through media literacy and creative uses of photography, film, and digital media.

Chung calls these subjects "virtual cosmopolitans," expanding on John Urry's concept of "imaginative travel" in which the act of taking photographs becomes the evidence of, and in a sense a substitute for, actual travel. Chung's examination of such mediated practices also reveals the impact of global media networks and transnational exchanges on individual and collective identities. In *Born into Brothels*, the subjects try to overcome their marginalization through the cultural power of photography, but the limitations of the film's perspective tends to reinforce the immobility of its subjects by observing them from a position from which they are excluded; the film fulfills the desires of privileged viewers more than those of the marginalized subjects. Chung argues that *City of Photos* presents a more inclusive form of virtual cosmopolitanism through the theoretical frame of what Miriam Hansen calls "vernacular modernism;" the "amazing appropriative flexibility" (Hansen) of media images and products is demonstrated by Indian subjects who take photographs of themselves in front of painted backdrops and digitally manipulate those photographs to travel virtually and to construct cosmopolitan identities. The film embodies Arjun Appadurai's concept of "mediascapes" that navigate "between sites of agency and globally defined fields of possibility;" the appropriation of various forms of local and global media enable subjects who are excluded from conventional practices of cosmopolitanism to create an alternative global imaginary and enact their desires.

In "Rethinking the Monstrous: Gender, Otherness, and Space in the Cinematic Storytelling of *Arrival* and *The Shape of Water*," Edward Chamberlain analyzes the films *The Shape of Water* and *Arrival* through the lenses of American studies, gender studies, and Latinx studies to reveal how the depiction of what he calls "collaborative Otherness" challenges conventional notions of monstrosity and critiques the political ideologies of the Cold War and the current global order. Monstrosity becomes a means of commenting on the ways that the U.S. government and institutions have historically abused and silenced people of color, women, and people who identify as LGBTQ; on the other hand, the films present alliances based on shared experiences of exclusion and unbelonging. In *The Shape of Water*, Elsa and Giles are solitary outsiders who bond through their shared status but also through their compassion for, and identification with, a creature marked institutionally as a monster to be caged and studied. In *Arrival*, Louise Banks is able to prevent global war by learning how to communicate with aliens who are seen as threats to humanity by governments around the world. The fear of the unknown is linked in the film to the inability or unwillingness to communicate, and this linguistic barrier is reflected by the escalating tensions between governments caused by leaders who fail to communicate with each other. Chamberlain cites Gloria Anzaldúa's concept of "border people" and Inderpal Grewal's concept of "transnational connectivities" to explicate how characters who share the experience of Otherness generated by discourses of gender, racialization, and monstrosity embody the possibility of collaboration and translation, bridging the institutionalized boundaries that divide individuals and cultures.

In "Sewing Lives: Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* and the Global Garment Industry," Sarah Garland combines discussions of the economics of the global fashion industry, the psychology of buying and wearing clothes, and the novel *Frankenstein* to explore the sociopolitical ramifications of "fast fashion" and its alternatives. Fast fashion is made possible by the global outsourcing of every element of the supply chain, producing clothes as cheap and disposable as fast food, and its growth is driven by increased consumption and lack of attachment to its disposable products. Garland reads Mary Shelley's novel as paradigmatic of our complex psychological relationship with intimate objects like clothes. *Frankenstein*'s creature is stitched together from the bodies of the poor and persecuted, reflecting the global labor market that exploits the unprotected citizens of poorer countries; Mark Sumner argues that "fast fashion's overproduction and overconsumption...is based on the globalization of indifference" to the exploitation of workers and damages to the environment. The novel allegorizes how fast fashion depends on erasing the process of production and affectively devaluing its products. The economic power and affective influence of fast fashion companies might be seen as monstrous; in response, various movements have attempted to create environmentally sustainable alternatives to the global fashion industry. Jonathan Chapman proposes the idea of "emotionally durable design" and argues that "durability" is more about attachment than production techniques. Kate Fletcher argues that sustainability requires a post-growth model of fashion in which identity is no longer based on consumption. Sustainable clothing movements need, Garland argues, to understand the affective relationships that people have to clothes and to overcome the psychological barriers produced by the expanding influence of the global fashion industry.

In "Postinternet Art of the Moving Image and the Disjunctures of the Global and the Local: Kim Hee-cheon and Other Young East Asian Artists," Jihoon Kim analyzes moving image works by three East Asian artists whose images and perspectives reflect the postinternet condition in which digital technologies and media networks fundamentally restructure people's subjectivities. But rather than expressing such conditions as universal and homogenizing, these artists express the contradictory and

unstable ways in which the global and the local interact in contemporary East Asia; their representations of the postinternet condition reflect the varied impact of globalization on local cultures, politics, and environments. Kim refers to a number of theorists to describe the aesthetics of the three artists: Nicolas Bourriaud's concept "postproduction" (recycling, refashioning, and recombining existing media); Hito Steyerl, who argues that such postproduction techniques become strategies to intervene in the accelerating and massive circulation of images and ideas; and Jorg Heiser's concept of "super-hybridity." Taiwanese artist Chen Chen-yu explores the regional flows of culture, data, and fine dust, using clouds as a metaphor for the complex ways in which the circulation of digital data shapes our cultural and environmental conditions. Chinese artist Lu Yang juxtaposes Chinese religious symbols and ideas with contemporary images derived from Western medicine, anatomy, and neuroscience; Lu expresses the dissolution of the boundaries between science and religion by transforming herself into a virtual avatar using 3D scanning technology and embedding her avatar in a digital environment in which anatomy, neuroscience, and religion are hybridized. Kim Hee-cheon's video trilogy represents the collapsing of virtual and physical worlds in the postinternet condition. These videos can be read as an essay film whose textual hybridity reflects Kim's fluid authorial subjectivity; Kim uses such super-hybridity to represent the infrastructural, cultural, and affective dimensions of Seoul as a digital landscape that overflows with contradictory technological, global, and local influences. These young East Asian artists use digital postproduction techniques and the aesthetics of super-hybridity to invent worlds that allow us to explore the complex intersections of the global and the local through grotesque images of monstrous bodies and disorienting spaces.

These essays reveal, through the analysis of a wide range of cultural texts within multiple geographic and sociopolitical contexts, that the expansion of the phenomenon and discourse of globalization is linked to the simultaneous expansion of the seemingly opposing discourses of identity politics and the restoration of local/national identities, and also remind us that what we call globalization is inextricably linked to the historical development of cold war politics and neoliberalism. They also reveal that the multiple spaces and intersecting forces of globalization open up possibilities for imagining and creating new identities and communities, as well as possible ways to resist global economic forces and dominant cultures. Given the concurrent debates about urgent problems such as global economic crisis, environmental disaster, and illegal immigration and refugees, and the inability of national governments and international organizations to solve such problems or even envision viable solutions, a critical reassessment of globalization and its effects on cultures deserves our attention more than ever. And the urgency of these global problems demand that we make visible the monstrous forces of an expanding and increasingly destructive globalization; no solutions can be envisioned without first representing and analyzing the monstrous global.

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Popular Kenyan Last Names, Their Meanings and Digital Presence



TL;DR: Popular Kenyan Last Names

- Kenyan surnames carry deep meaning, reflecting birth order, time of birth, seasons, lineage, and ethnic identity.
- Across communities like the Kikuyu, Luo, Kalenjin, Kamba, and Luhya, surnames preserve family history thrc generations.
- Today, your surname is also **digital real estate**.
- Domain names operate on a first-come, first-served basis, if someone registers *yoursurname.co.ke*, reclaiming it can be difficult or expensive.
- Influential figures like **Wangari Maathai** and **Ngũgĩ wa Thiong’o** highlighted the cultural power of names, today that power extends online.
- Securing your surname as a domain protects your family’s digital identity, future business opportunities, a professional credibility.
- You do not need to build a website immediately, you simply need to secure the name before someone els does.

A Kenyan surname carries ethnic group identity, history, geography, and family stories. They often reflect birth order among siblings, time of birth, seasons, events, physical traits, or lineage. It is like a family line that passes from father to child, generation after generation.

But here is what most families are overlooking: your last name is also digital real estate.

Every day, more personal names are being registered as domains. Once someone secures *yoursurname.co.ke* you cannot claim it back easily, if ever.

Before you continue reading, secure your last name for future use. If it is still available, secure it first.

How helpful was this article?



Terrible, didn't help me at all!



Meh, it was OK



Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

- [Luo Surnames](#)
- [Kamba Surnames](#)
- [Kalenjin Surnames](#)
- [Luhya Surnames](#)
- [How Kenyan Naming Traditions Work](#)
- [Examples of Powerful Kenyan Names](#)
- [Why Risk Losing Your Name Online?](#)

Kenyan Last Names and Their Meanings

In Kenya, surnames are inherited from the father. The father’s name becomes the child’s last name and the grandfather’s name echoes in the grandchildren. This is true across almost all ethnic communities — Kikuyu, Luo, Kamba, Kalenjin, Luhya, and beyond.

Here are some of the most popular Kenyan surnames born from this principle:

Kikuyu Surnames

The Kikuyu are Kenya’s largest ethnic community and their surnames are among the most common in the country. Many are rooted in birth order, family structure, and ancestral lineage.

Mwangi – Often interpreted as ‘rapid expansion’ — someone strong and fast-growing. One of Kenya’s most common surnames.

Kamau – A boy born after a girl in Kikuyu naming tradition. Now widely used as a family surname.

Kariuki – Linked to agricultural growth; ‘one who springs up.’ Common across the Mt. Kenya region.

Njoroge – Associated with cattle herding or pastoral traditions.

Kinyua – Linked to farming and cultivation roots.

Njenga – Tied to resilience and strength within the family.

Karanja – Often associated with leadership or authority within ethnic group structures.

Ndungu – Refers to someone born in dry or drought conditions.

Gichuru – Associated with ethnic group lineage among the Kikuyu.

How helpful was this article?



Terrible, didn't help me at all!



Meh, it was OK



Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

Luo Surnames

The Luo of Western Kenya have a distinctive naming system built around time of birth. These names are deep tied to lineage and the father’s name passes forward as a surname through generations.

Odhiambo – A boy born in the evening.

Otieno – A boy born at night. One of the most recognizable Luo surnames.

Ochieng – A boy born during daylight hours.

Omondi – A boy born early in the morning.

Onyango – A boy born in the early morning hours. A very common Luo surname.

Owino – A Luo surname tied to lineage and paternal ancestry.

Achieng – A girl born during daylight; also carried as a family surname.

Anyango – A girl born in the morning.

Atieno – A girl born at night.

Kamba Surnames

The Kamba of Eastern Kenya have strong naming traditions tied to family events, birth circumstances, and seasonal cycles. Their surnames reflect a deep connection to land and lineage.

Mutua – Often given to a child born after the loss of another child. A name that carries both grief and renewal.

Musyoka – Connected to agricultural seasons or ethnic group lineage.

Kioko – Refers to someone born in the morning.

Kilonzo – A Kamba surname linked to family lineage.

Muli – Often refers to ‘second born’ in Kamba tradition.

Mulwa – Associated with traditional Kamba naming customs.

Nzioka – Refers to someone born during specific seasonal periods.

How helpful was this article?



Terrible, didn't help me at all!



Meh, it was OK



Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

- Kiptoo** – A boy born at night in Kalenjin tradition.
- Kibet** – A boy born during the day.
- Kiprono** – A boy born during migration or movement.
- Kiprotich** – A boy born during sunny daylight hours.
- Ruto** – Associated with birth along a journey or road. Now one of Kenya’s most recognized surnames.
- Koech** – Linked to agricultural or environmental birth conditions.
- Langat** – A Kalenjin name associated with nature and the environment.
- Rotich** – Linked to cattle-keeping traditions.
- Biwott** – A Kalenjin surname connected to ethnic group identity.
- Sang** – A short Kalenjin surname tied to lineage.
- Too** – A shortened Kalenjin surname linked to birth timing.
- Chebet** – A girl born during the day; also used as a family surname.
- Cherono** – A girl born during times of migration or travel.

Luhya Surnames

The Luhya of Western Kenya are a diverse cluster of sub-communities. Their surnames carry strong ties to heritage, ancestry, and seasonal farming traditions.

- Barasa** – A name tied to Luhya ethnic group lineage.
- Simiyu** – Associated with ethnic group identity across Luhya communities.
- Were** – Tied to heritage and ancestry; common across Western Kenya.
- Masinde** – Popular in Western Kenya, connected to ethnic group names.
- Wekesa** – A boy born during harvest season — one of the most recognizable Luhya surnames.
- Naliaka** – A Luhya female name referring to birth during the weeding season.
- Nabwire** – Often refers to a girl born at night.

How helpful was this article?



Terrible, didn't help me at all!



Meh, it was OK



Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

Many communities name children based on time of birth.

Among the Luo:

- Otieno refers to a boy born at night
- Odhiambo refers to a boy born in the evening
- Ochieng refers to a boy born during the day
- Achieng refers to a girl born during daylight

Among the Kalenjin:

- Kip often refers to a boy
- Chep or Jep often refers to a girl
- Kipchoge relates to being born near granaries
- Chebet often refers to a girl born during the day

Other surnames reflect **birth order**.

In Kikuyu naming traditions:

- Kamau is often a boy born after a girl
- Wanjiru can reflect a specific order in the family structure

Some **names are linked to seasons and agriculture**, which makes sense when land and farming shaped generations.

Examples:

- Wekesa refers to someone born during harvest
- Muthoni relates to harvest season
- Naliaka refers to birth during weeding season

Then there are surnames tied to **circumstances or events**.

- Mutua is often given to a child born after the loss of another
- Ndungu can refer to drought conditions
- Ruto can relate to birth along a journey

Finally, many surnames are deeply tied to ethnic group identity and lineage. In communities like the Luhya and Kikuyu, surnames signal extended family connections and ancestral roots.

This structure matters. When you see that your surname carries information about time, season, struggle, or lineage, it stops being “just a name.” It becomes a heritage that deserves protection and forward thinking.

How helpful was this article?



Terrible, didn't help me at all!



Meh, it was OK



Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

If someone else controls your surname online, they control what appears when your name is searched. Visibility under your own name should not be left to chance.

Why Risk Losing Your Name Online?

Here is the reality: domain registries operate on a first-come, first-served basis.

There is no system that protects surnames by tribe, lineage, or cultural ownership. If someone registers `mwangi.co.ke` before you, it legally belongs to them even if your family has carried that name for generations.

Because surnames pass through the father’s line, one domain registration protects an entire family tree, not just one person.

And this is already happening.

Common Kenyan surnames are being registered by:

- Businesses building household names
- Individuals building personal brands
- Diaspora Kenyans securing .com versions
- Domain investors who see value in common surnames

The more common the surname, the higher the risk.

Think about names like Mwangi, Otieno, Kipchoge, Mutua, Wekesa. These are not rare, which makes them attractive as domains.

Now add two more factors:

1. Kenya’s digital growth is accelerating.
2. More professionals are building websites instead of relying only on social media.

With all that in mind, you do not need to build a website immediately. You only need to secure the name.

For the cost of a domain registration, you protect:

1. Your family’s digital identity
2. Future business opportunities
3. Professional credibility
4. Email addresses under your own name

How helpful was this article?



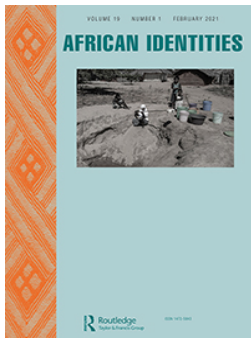
Terrible, didn't help me at all!



Meh, it was OK



Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!



What's in a name? Reinventing Luo naming system in Kenya's ethnopolitical landscape

Belindah Okello

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ARTICLE



What's in a name? Reinventing Luo naming system in Kenya's ethnopolitical landscape

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines an emergent naming subculture gaining popularity among ethnic Luo in the urban areas of Mombasa and Nairobi. The paper posits that the naming pattern is embedded in the development of Kenya's ethnopolitical landscape which has placed ethnic Luo at an economically, socially and politically disadvantaged position. Though popular in linguistic and anthropological circles, the field of anthroponymy has received little attention from Africanist historians. This dearth is especially curious since naming systems still bear significant meaning to large segments of the continent's populations. Names are pointers to identities; identities that have been used world over to create binaries of 'us' and 'them'. Every so often, identities have been determinants of individuals' primary existence. Because of its centrality in existentiality, societies constantly consolidate, manipulate and restructure identities in order to fit in, dominate or survive. This evaluation of the development and changes of Luo naming system is therefore an attempt at understanding identities reimagined to adapt to a society's history, systems and structures.

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Naming systems; identity; ethnicity; Luo; governance; Kenya

1 Introduction

The theme of ethnicity and how it has manifested through Kenya's history since the colonial period features prominently in Yvonne Adhiambo's novel *Dust* (Adhiambo, 2014). This paper borrows from Adhiambo's theme on naming and ethnicity to argue that the collective memory and experiences of ethnic Luo in Kenya has contributed to the emergence and the continuous adoption of a new naming system. A main character in *Dust*; Keya, was able to move ranks and become powerful in the Kenya police partly due to his name not overtly revealing his ethnic identity. The name 'Keya', derived from localizing KAR (Kings African Rifles battalion of World War II), helped him navigate the ethnopolitical landscape in Kenya's early post-independence civil service. His counterpart Nyipir Oganda had a different experience. In analyzing the adoption of this new naming system, the paper will endeavor to answer the question of to what extent Kenya's history with ethnicity and how it has been experienced by the Luo has contributed to the emergence of this practice.

Secondly, the paper will look into why the new naming system is becoming more prevalent amongst middle-class Luo, and in the urban areas.

Individuals use ethnic identities to categorize themselves and others for purposes of interaction (Barth, 1998, p. 11). The differences applied to categorize are usually not objective but only regarded as significant by the actors. These identities enable humans to feel they are part of an organizational structure and sets them apart from those categorized as others. Appiah (2018) describes identities as imagined commonalities that create unity within an in-group and ostracize those they consider to be of a differing out-group. He argues that identities are fluid and are built upon by making alterations and additions to a primary idea. Giving an example of Western culture which he posits began as an attempt to counter the influence of a burgeoning Islamic culture (but would later morph into a complete system of governance, architecture, moralities, etc.) identities he argues, become reinforced at the locus of conflict rather than being the primary cause of it.

The paper begins by outlining some literature on naming and identity, underlining the nexus between the two themes, and hence outlines how anthroponyms can be used as tools for deciphering the history of people. This will be followed by discussing the theoretical framework by which this analysis will be understood. Then, I will delve into the evolution of Luo naming system beginning with naming practices in the precolonial era and weave through the changes occasioned by various factors in history until finally coming to a conclusion in the present era of the new modifications. Next, the paper will tackle the methodology used to collect information on the new naming practices and outline the results of the study from the interviewees' perspective. Finally, the paper will scrutinize the development of Kenya's ethno-political landscape juxtaposing it against the experience of the Luo; and in this explain how these developments triggered the adoption of a new naming system.

2 Literature Review

A name is one of the most explicit pointers of identity. Likaka (2009), posits that names constitute the essence of the individual, embodying their experiences, memories, thoughts and actions. He asserts that names are sites of observation and perception, and have been used as avenues for encoding myths, metaphors, and for reflection. Suzman (1994, p. 253) argues that names are not arbitrary labels but have sociocultural meanings and possess referential functions. Herbert (1999) agrees to this assertion in his assessment of African political names, arguing that personal names offer social commentary and that names in Africa are used as avenues for keeping the history of people.

One of the most prolific works on the philosophy guiding African naming is Mbiti's *African Religions and Philosophy* (Mbiti, 1969). This work points out the importance given to the processes of naming in various African societies and includes examples of ceremonies and general guidelines applied by different communities. Mbiti maintains that it is through these processes that a child is connected to not only a family but also to an entire ethnic group. The converging of the living, the dead and a newborn in naming processes relays the significance a name plays in the formation of communal identity. Agyekum's (2006) examination of the sociocultural meanings attributed to Akan names details the complexities of gender, social standing, place, among other factors involved in arriving at

particular personal names. This work shows that in Africa, a name is arrived at after careful considerations. Work on naming practices among the Luo includes examination of their clan naming system (Malo, 1953; Mboya, 1938; Ogot, 1967; Southall, 1952); the works revealing a connection between Luo migration and settlement pattern in their clan naming practices. Southall demonstrates the links between clan naming with a progenitor thus situating naming within social identity. Mboya's elaboration of the significance of 'proper' Luo socialization through practices such as naming, and his arguments that it is through such that the cooperate association of the Luo will survive in the face of colonialism and the foreign cultures of urban areas reveals the importance placed on identity in culturally ambiguous locales.

Nyambi et al. (2016) posit that names are important yet often underestimated socio-political-cultural sites on which some of the most significant events and processes of the post colony can be read. Naming patterns change over time and are often influenced by people's history. Likaka's (2009) work on the naming of Europeans in the Congo, and how it was influenced by their experience of colonialism reveals that names can be used as avenues of expression of experiences hence as subtle responses to lived experiences. Suzman (1994) analysis of the changes in naming systems among the Zulu from traditional naming patterns and their transitioning through processes of western acculturation situates naming within the history of people. Epstein's (1958) study of the urban community in a mining town in the Copperbelt region of Zambia recognizes that social relationships develop within a setting that is continuously changing, and affected by increasing diversification of customs. The findings of these authors correspond to Luo naming practices which have changed and evolved, the changes being subject to a myriad of factors including; pre-colonial migrations, Christianity, colonial and post-colonial labor migrations, Western education, among other factors. Colonial labor migrations and later rural-urban migrations especially contributed to the development of what has been termed as 'distinct Luo names'; the distinct character being almost all male names beginning with the prefix 'O' and female names with the prefix 'A'. Currently, however, there is a shift in Luo naming system among the young urban middle-class population. As Dixon (2000) argues, 'who we are' is often intimately related to questions of 'where we are'. This paper will interrogate the connection between this change in naming pattern in the urban areas, and Kenya's history with negative ethnicity.

3 Theoretical Framework

The theory of historical trauma will be applied in analyzing the changes of naming patterns among middle-class ethnic Luo living in the urban areas of Nairobi and Mombasa. Historical trauma is a term that has been used to describe the long-term impact of colonization, cultural suppression, and historical oppression of individuals. The construct has been mostly applied in the study of indigenous peoples in the Western world, including Native Americans in the United States and Aboriginal peoples like the Inuit and Metis of Canada (Crawford, 2014; Kirmayer et al., 2014; Walters et al., 2011). The term is also mainly used in psychology and in the medical field to analyze the physiological and psychological effects traumatic experiences of oppression have on a group. Historical trauma spans multiple generations, such that contemporary members of an affected group may experience trauma-related symptoms without having been

present for the past traumatizing events (Crawford, 2014). Effects of historical trauma are usually negative.

Although historical trauma has been used to analyze the medical effects of oppression, the concept can also be applied in analyzing the positive coping mechanisms that can/ have been applied by groups of oppressed individuals. Kirmayer et al. (2014) argue that the continued oppression of people is in actuality a result of existing structures of oppression rather than the trauma in itself. Hence, contends that the theory of historical trauma should be more appropriately used to analyze the adaptations individuals/groups develop in order to minimize the effects of oppression. This paper shall apply historical trauma in this context. The paper will argue that a large section of especially middle-class Luo in Mombasa and Nairobi are cognizant of the possibility of their ethnicity becoming a hindrance in their quest for upward social mobility and even their personal safety. This affirmation stems from memories of oppression in successive post-independence Kenyan governments. Coupled with uncertainties over the new political dispensation of devolution and decentralization, their experiences of historical trauma are pushing them towards adopting names giving anonymity to their children.

4 Evolution of Luo naming System

Before embarking on a narrative evaluation of the changes and evolution of Luo naming system, I shall illustrate the changes in the following three Tables.

Table 1. Examples of cultural Luo names.

Name	Origins of the name
Gor	Ancient Luo warrior
Wadiya	Found mainly in the Suba regions. Name believed to have Bantu origins
Gombe	One of the progenies of the Ugenya clans
Boro	One of the progenies of the Alego clans

N.B. Traditional naming was largely gender neutral, though it was more common for women to possess 'male names' than the other way.

Table 2. Examples of 'common' Luo names.

Circumstance surrounding birth	Luo translation	Male	Female
Rain	'Koth	Okoth	Akoth
Mist	'Luoch	Oluoch	Aluoch
Sun	'Chieng	Ochieng	Achieng
Night	'Tieno	Otieno	Atieno

N.B. The supposed commonality shall be explained in the narration

Table 3. Examples of new names gaining ground.

Positive trait considered	Luo translation	Male	Female
Strength	Teko	Teko	Teko
Blessings	Gweth/Mich	Gweth/Mich	Gweth/Mich
Happiness	Mor	Mor	Mor
Shining star	Sulwe	Sulwe	Sulwe

Luo cultural naming system has been captured in various academic and fictional literatures (Malo, 1953; Mbiti, 1969; Mboya, 1938; Ogola, 1994; Ogot, 1967; Southall, 1952). Children were named by their kin and names given were in most cases those of the living dead or ancestral figures who wanted the continuation of their legacy in the living. A preferred name for a child would come to a kin (*wat*) in form of a dream; the dead relation asking the *wat* to relay their desire to have a child named after them (Ogola, 1994). If no dead relation willed to be renamed, parents had a free hand in giving out a name (Ohanga, Oral interview 20 June 2018). In such a circumstance, parents would give a child a personal name which usually was an indication of the circumstances surrounding their birth. A prefix 'O' or 'A' would in most cases be affixed to a circumstance to arrive at a name. If, for example, a child was born on a rainy day, their name would mean rain 'koth'; thus 'Akoth', or 'Okoth' for a girl and boy, respectively. The concept of family name did not exist and individuals' names included a personal name, together with a 'surname' which was the personal name of one's legal father. 'Surnames' were therefore different for members within a patriarchal group.

Arguably, the abovementioned naming system is an oversimplified representation of an elaborate process. Naming systems were in actuality complicated processes often punctuated with the application of extra-ordinary naming patterns and ritual performances to fulfil special circumstances. There would be, for example, a different naming system applicable if there was a general belief that evil may befall an infant. The above narration however constitutes the basic of naming systems among the Luo in instances where no exceptional circumstances were in play. In addition, the emergent naming pattern in the analysis is contextualized within the transitions occasioned by colonial experiences which will be discussed further herein; hence, this narration will suffice.

A dramatic shift in Luo naming system came about in the colonial period through two major avenues. Firstly, the introduction of a formal education system, initially given by Christian missionaries who required conversion (Okello & Nyakwaka, 2016) led to the adoption of western names baptized as 'Christian names'. Hereafter bearing a European name together with an ethnic name became the norm first among the educated, but later the practice was evenly adopted. Secondly, colonization came with rapid urbanization and an advent of labor migration with a large section of ethnic Luo becoming labor migrants in upcoming urban areas, colonial farms, and industrial districts. Migrant laborers were initially unaccompanied young men (Janmohamed, 1979; Stichter, 1985). Later, however, male laborers were allowed to tag their wives and families along to live with them (Cooper, 1987). This meant that a young nuclear family was broken from the direct influence of extended family relations. As a consequence, earlier restrictions on naming patterns became weakened and naming shifted from being a communal activity to a personal one. Migrant parents thence began relying on circumstances surrounding their children's birth to name them. The time of day and surrounding weather conditions became the most common of circumstance; thus, the Luo born in the urban areas began acquiring characteristic names (See Table 2). To other ethnic groups especially, all Luo names began with prefixes 'O' and 'A'. Other names were however still given by extended relatives and even friends whenever the family in the urban area visited. Individuals sometimes possessed as many as eight names which were fluid, and easily changed to satisfy varied interests.¹

In the later colonial and much of the post-colonial years, government bureaucratization in form of birth certificates and identity cards meant that individuals were stuck with names originally ascribed. Henceforth, changing one's ethnic name to fit into particular circumstances became impossible. Kenya's social and political space was at the same time, increasingly becoming ethnically divided. The ethnic structuring of society gradually determined personal fortunes and in time one's name directly influenced their chances of upward mobility and even, personal safety. These insecurities were especially felt by the Luo in urban areas. Soon, Luo parents came to the realization that if their children names become anonymous to surrounding ethnic groups, they were much more likely to survive Kenya's ethnicized space. Hence, a subculture constituting of a new naming system is slowly being adopted with the purposes of keeping Luo ethnic identity intact but anonymous. The parents hope that this action will safeguard their children's personal safety and at the same time ensures a wider space for upward social mobility.

4.1 Methodology and Results of the study

This paper is part of a larger inquiry on the challenges of integration among urban ethnic Luo of Kenya. The overall inquiry interviewed respondents from ages 15, but data for this paper constituted only a subset of the whole sample group; that is families whose children possess covert² Luo names. These respondents numbered 20. An evaluation of the naming system among this sample group revealed a departure from the traditional ethnic Luo practice of the circumstances of one's birth determining one's name. In addition, there is a conscious choice to move away from the use of the prefix 'O' and 'A' (See Table 3). Obviously, not all Luo names begin with the prefixes 'O' and 'A'. In homes where the father's surname did not begin with these prefixes, the concept of family name was more likely adopted. In multi-ethnic homes, the non-Luo parent would usually push for giving of anonymous Luo names compared to obvious ones. The patriarchal nature of most households aided in reaching the compromises towards the new naming system with most male Luo partners willing to adopt covert Luo names rather than have children identified with names from their maternal ethnic group. The prevalence of this new naming pattern is highest among middle-class families (compared to low-income families); and increases with a decrease in the age of parents. The prevalence can be explained by understanding the characterization of the middle class in Nairobi and Mombasa. As analyzed by Boanada-Fuchs and Gez et al. (2016), Kroeker (2017), and Institute of Economic Affairs (2016), the middle class in Kenya's urban spaces have more interactions (work, marriages, school) with other ethnic groups than their counterparts in the rural areas, or even among the urban poor. They also have less linkages with their ancestral homes³ with some being third and fourth generations of colonial immigrant kin. In addition, the middle class have less communal socio-support mechanisms comparable to those experienced by ethnic counterparts in the rural areas and among the urban poor. The middle class, therefore, have limited support mechanisms to fall back on in case they fall on hard times. Thus, an adaptation to their identity to mitigate against these hard times seems appropriate.

Where one ethnic group has control of the means of production utilized by another group, a relationship of inequality and stratification is likely to occur (Barth, 1998). He adds that in most cases, a section in the minority group reacts to their situation and become

agents of change. These agents of change are the persons with greater contacts and more dependence on goods and organization of the society controlled by the majority. In their quest to participate in wider social systems they would usually choose the following strategies. Firstly, they may attempt to pass and become in cooperated in the pre-established majority society and cultural group. Secondly, they may accept their minority status but seek to reduce and accommodate their minority disabilities while participating in the systems controlled by the majority. A third option would be to choose to emphasize their ethnic identity, using it to develop new positions and patterns of organization. This paper discusses the adoption of the second option by middle-class Luo (the agents of change), revealing that the new naming system is a response to minimize the effects of ethnicity in an urban setting.

4.2 The development of Kenya's ethnopolitical space

Conflict amongst ethnic groups was a common feature in pre-colonial societies. Ethnic groups regularly battled each other over space and resources; thus, displacement and assimilation of sections of populations was not uncommon. Distinct ethnic identities were not particularly formed and ethnic groups drew their common identities majorly from their clan system rather than from aspects such as language or shared history (Ambler, 1988). The Abamarachi sections of the Abaluhya, for example, would constantly raid the Abatachoni eventually forcing the latter to construct defensive forts (Ogutu, 1991). Another example would be the Luo of Alego who considered the Luo of Gem, Sakwa, Kisuma and other subgroups as a different tribe (sic) common language notwithstanding (Nundu, 1982; Ogot, 1967; Southall, 1952).

Colonialism radically restructured the face of ethnic conflict; majorly through the creation, encouragement and institutionalization of clear ethnic identities among African populations (Ambler, 1988; Berman & Wolff, 1978). Ambler opines that defining ethnicity, with specific ethnic groups possessing clear and definite abilities was a scheme to enable easier subjugation of local populations. Berman (1990) contends adding that ethnicizing and the ensuing preferential treatment for particular groups resulted in not only suspicion amongst ethnic groups but also growing resentment towards each other. Imagined ethnic identities would later become crucial instruments of state organization and control of populations.

Since the colonial period, the ability to control all organs of the state has been a key element in the development of the bourgeoisie class. The colonial administration enabled this control by way of creation of a powerful civil service, which controlled local politics and economy and ultimately led to state capture⁴ with its attendant economic and social controls of the population (Bienen, 1974; Himbara, 1994). This continued in the post colony and the battle for control of the civil service (which was essentially the battle to become part of the bourgeoisie) shaped the development of Kenya's ethnopolitical space (Burbidge, 2016; Odinga, 1995; Shilaho, 2018). In the immediate post-colonial period, the emergent African bourgeoisie class determined to protect their position, ensured that all powerful posts in the civil service, police and armed forces were filled by their fellow tribespeople. Thus, the ethnic group of whoever was in power became the dominant group in the civil service and ensured tribal hegemony. Ethnicity influenced government formation and operation, influenced opposition to government, and was used as

a defining factor to include/exclude certain groups in/from political participation. The control of the organizational structure of the state was fused to ethnicities and this determined economic fortunes. It became highly unlikely for an individual to acquire anything without it having been stamped by organs of the civil service. A 1972 ILO report aptly described the situation as:

Kenya inherited a very lopsided economy already organised for the effective maintenance of very different ways of life for a tiny minority on the one hand, and a very large majority on the other. Kenyanisation has radically changed the racial composition of the group of people at the centre of power and many of its policies, but has had only a limited effect on the mechanisms which maintain its dominance. The power of the centre over the periphery may well be greater today than it was before (ILO, 1972, pp. 83–102)

Luo exclusion from government (civil service) began with the Odinga/Kenyatta ideological battle shortly after independence. Odinga preferred socialism arguing that it was best suited in helping African nations achieve development after the experiences of colonialism (Cullen, 2018; Oruka, 1992). He added that Africans had inherent socialism structures within their communities thus the African state would be best suited to follow a familiar path towards development. President Kenyatta preferred capitalism arguing that to spur development, the country needed to quickly integrate into the world economy through the capitalist system of free market (Cullen, 2018). This ideological war led to the breakup of the independence party Kenya African National Union (KANU) and the formation of the socialist Kenya Peoples Union (KPU) by Odinga. The Luo effectively became Odinga's associates by way of ethnic linkages. As a result, they became politically side-lined, labelled anti-government and were linked with opposition politics, a tag which made the community a prime target for political and economic exclusion (Omollo, Oral interview 13 December 2017; Bienen, 1974; Himbara, 1994; Omulo & Williams, 2018; Shilaho, 2018). This was best exhibited in their exclusion from the civil service.

Other than its mechanisms of controlling state organs, the civil service was the most attractive agency of employment. At independence, Kenya's labor laws were adapted from the colonial laws whose practices were quite discriminatory to the African worker. Although steps had been made to improve the position of laborers through trade unionism and legislations, labor laws were still relatively weak. In addition, a large section of the population was uneducated hence unable to fully understand and internalize matters labor rights. Being part of the civil service was more or less the only known mechanism of labor protection. Because of the relatively small size of the civil service (owing to low education standards) civil servants also received perks including the possibility of time off to pursue higher education and trainings which would later translate to promotions. Entry into the civil service, therefore, became a crucial step towards upward economic and social mobility.

The economic downturn of the 1970s greatly increased the value of employment in the civil service. In a country that was yet to recover from the effects of colonialism, inflation, low wages, and a raised cost of living led to a staggering deterioration of the economy. In an effort to appease the civil service which was the main tool for state control, the Kenya Public Structure and Remuneration Committee formed in 1971 made recommendations to allow civil servants engage in private businesses to supplement incomes. This move

goaded corruption and negative ethnicity as civil servants began using their position to grow and expand private enterprises. Ethnic brokerage became pivotal in the entry to the civil service with the broker becoming an institutionalized feature in the work environment (ILO, 1972; Omulo & Williams, 2018). At the grassroots level, life became harder as everyone struggled to position themselves in the new economic dispensation. Citizens became easily susceptible and readily receptive to the political rhetoric of 'us versus them'. Ethnicity thus became a weapon in the struggle for access to available resources (Omulo & Williams, 2018).

The beginning of multi-party politics in the 1990s aggravated the ethnicized landscape in Kenya. At the time for clamor for multi-partyism, president Daniel Moi warned that multi-party politics would lead to the division of the country into ethnic enclaves. When it surely seemed that multiparty was on its way back, calls for federalism (*majimboism*) meant to protect ethnic spheres of influence became louder. Politicians from the Moi's Rift Valley province backyard became prime pushers of federalism, calling for the area to be for the exclusive political nature of the Kalenjin ethnic groups. They openly called for the restoration of the province to its pristine Kalenjin land and expulsion of the Kikuyu, Luo and Luhya (Human rights Watch/Africa Watch, 1993; Weekly Review Magazine, 1992). Moi's 'prophecy' on multi-party politics becoming divisive came to pass at the repeal of section 2A of the constitution which ended one-party rule and allowing multiparty politics. The move triggered the beginning of politically instigated ethnic clashes, and this time again; the Luo became targets for violence.

4.3 Immediate triggers of name change

The urban Luo resolve to change their naming system are directly related to lived experiences, combined with memories of exclusion in the past. Urban Luo live amongst other ethnic groups. The current generation has lived through the violence connected to the introduction of multi-party politics, the infamous 2007 post-election flare-up, and they continue witnessing ethnic bigotry exhibited in the politics of the day. In addition, exclusion from access to resources to enable upward mobility by successive post-independence regimes constitutes their collective ethnic memory.

Due to the fact that the opposition party FORD was headed by an ethnic Luo Oginga Odinga, the initial ethnic violence connected to multi-party politics was meted on the Luo.⁵ However, as multipartyism took shape and multiple political parties began registering ethnic bases, the pattern of violence changed and the Kikuyu began bearing the brunt of election-related violence. In the 2007 post-election flare-up, victims in pro-government areas narrated how they were confronted and forced to produce national identity cards; and if one's bore a Luo name they were attacked (Human Rights Watch Report, 2008; Ogada, Oral Interview 27 January 2018). Ogada said that this incidence led to the decision of naming his children with covert Luo names.

The post-2007 political rhetoric has also been largely anti-Luo. This has been goaded by the growth of the media and ICT that has enabled fast and widespread information sharing, hence making it quite easy to spew ethnic hatred and advance ethnic nationalism to a huge audience. Social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter are popular platforms where anti-Luo sentiments are continuously broadcast. Vernacular radio stations have also been accused of encouraging ethnic bigotry by propagating disinformation and

messages of intolerance that have manipulated the public to resort to violence. The use of obscure and metaphorical language, coupled with wrong contextualization of discussions, make radio stations powerful incitement agents (Media Council of Kenya, 2015). In 2014, for example, when there occurred a terrorist attack in Mpeketoni Lamu district, it was widely circulated (metaphorically of course) in vernacular stations that the opposition leader Raila Odinga was responsible for the attack. This led to violent 'revenge' attacks on Luo not only in Mpeketoni, but in areas as far away as Nairobi's informal settlements of Mathare and Kibera. On several occasions, leaflets have appeared in the urban areas of Nakuru, Eldoret, and Nairobi asking the Luo to leave for their rural homes or face violence (Gitonga, in Standard newspaper, 2014; Capital FM Kenya). In the run-up to the election of 2017 and the immediate period of the disputed election results, random attacks were also meted on the Luo with sexual violence meted on both men and women, forceful circumcision being the main abuse meted on men⁶ (Omulo & Williams, 2018; Kenya National Commission of Human Rights 2017, 2018). Thus, the Luo are increasingly become aware of the need for a covert Luo identity.

The new naming system includes a process of parents identifying a positive trait they wish for their child; translating the word into its ethnic Luo form, hence giving a child a name with a Luo meaning. Such positive features could be strength (Teko), Hope (Hawi), Blessings (Gweth, Mich) Happiness (Mor) among others. Hence, names such as 'Gweth, and Hawi' are gaining popularity while the usual 'Okoth' and 'Aluoch' are losing ground. Parents are hopeful that the ethnically obscure name will enable their children navigate Kenya's ethnically divided society while at the same time; the parents get to pass an aspect of their culture onto their offspring.

5. Conclusion

Identities and feelings of belonging are crucial socio-psycho elements required in the overall development of individuals. Identities have however been also used as tools of oppression hence forcing individuals to apply mechanisms to survive repressive spaces. Grounded on the premise that the new naming system adopted by the Luo is a result of their collective memory and trauma, the paper argues that ethnic Luo, especially in urban areas, are trying to navigate Kenya's ethnicized landscape to enable participation in a system organized to their disadvantage. A new naming system ensures their children get to be Luo among the Luo, while at the same time cushions them from the effects of negative ethnicity while they live amongst other ethnic groups.

Many African governments encounter challenges in managing issues of ethnic diversity. In Kenya, the theme of ethnicity has been a recurring feature in local and international debates, becoming amplified especially during electoral periods. The prominence of this theme points to the need for serious attention and concerted efforts in seeking solutions in its management. Previously suggested solutions such as negotiated democracy in the form of devolution and decentralization have only compounded the problem which manifests in contests between communities during election periods. The high stakes involved in local politics since the introduction of devolution has only increased the risk of communal conflict in local political arenas; and has led to balkanization and the creation of dichotomies of locals and immigrants. Power-sharing options such as the arrangements after the 2007 violence, where power was shared between the president and prime minister managed to only lull disquiet at the top while feelings of discontent

continued simmering at grassroots level. Given that the contests over identities are usually related to resource redistribution, the Kenyan government would probably better manage ethnic animosities by not only leveling the playing field on matters access to resources but also improving the general standards of living for its citizenry.

The processes of government bureaucratization have been a major way in which ethnic identities have been highlighted and amplified. The Kenyan system of identification, for example, is adopted from the colonial registration system whose main agenda was to control the movement of labor. The acquisition of an identity card in Kenya today is a tedious process that has to be approved by authorities not only from one's current residency but also from one's parents. These details which are highlighted in one's identity card only end up unnecessarily amplifying identities and putting the citizenry at precarious positions in case of ethnic conflict. The continuance of registration of ethnic numbers whose main purpose is arguably for negotiating political positionality has also been damaging to efforts towards national cohesion. The 2018 census questionnaire, for example, required the input of one's ethnic group to the chagrin of, especially multi-ethnic homes. Government bureaucratization policies, therefore, need to be overhauled as the current policies solidify ethnic identities to the detriment of national cohesion.

Given that the adopted naming system is a new phenomenon, its effect on Luo identity and efficacy in navigating Kenya's ethnicized space is yet to be established. If the projected outcomes are realized and this adaptation becomes successful in minimizing their disabilities and disadvantages; Kenyan communities may need to consider conversations on reimagining identities as a method of managing negative ethnicity.

Notes

1. The colonial industrial economy preferred non contracted casual laborers who could be acquired and detached on demand. To ensure they received the best from their workers, industries would frequently ask employees to refer workers they knew would perform. Room for nepotism was created thus laborers frequently changed names to acquire wage labor. A more detailed analysis of the labor practices in the colonial period can be found in works of Stichter (1985) and Cooper (1987).
2. Covert to surrounding ethnic groups
3. Eighteen of the sampled middle class had children who could barely speak Luo language. They were also having less visits to their rural homes, and their children some of whom were as old as fifteen had had no or only a few visits to their rural homes. Seven parents who were second-generation urbanites and nine who were third generation, were unable to trace particularities of their roots (clan names, extended family) and only knew of the names of their rural homes. This was in contrast to the four low-income households where individuals tended to know their extended kin not only in the urban areas, but in rural areas most of whom they had never had contact with. Most of the middle-class parents and all the children considered their urban residences rather than their rural homes as their permanent abodes.
4. European colonial administrators in Kenya oscillated between being private citizens in business ventures and public administrators. This created a situation where those in government ended up consolidating all instruments of administration to ensure their private interests in the colony were foremost considered.
5. The first case of ethnic clashes began in 29 October 1991 at Meteitei Farm in Tinderet, Nandi district. Luo farm workers houses were torched by a group of Kalenjin warriors. Leaflets were distributed arguing the Luo to leave the area, and the Kericho Kisumu border became a war zone.

6. The Luo-other Kenyan ethnic groups division has been mainly along the question of circumcision. Traditionally, ethnic Luo do not perform circumcision as a rite of passage to adulthood and in times of conflict, other ethnic groups label them as children.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes on contributor

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